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The Road to Dalal Street

When we had known each other for over a month, I asked Pradeep if he could arrange a job for me at a broker's office. My request seemed to have caught him off guard, and I suspect his initial hesitation may have had to do with the fear of losing a willing listener.

From whatever little I had understood about the stock market from Pradeep, I was clear about one thing – I did not want to work in a broker's back office checking share certificates, settling accounts and shuffling paper. I wanted to be in the midst of the action on the trading floor, shouting orders to buy and sell shares.

At the same time, I was aware that my path to the trading ring would have to start from a broker's back office. I prevailed on Pradeep to get me any job in a broker's office. Seeing my determination, he finally gave in. He seemed to have also sensed that I had bigger things in mind despite a willingness to start small.

'I don't know what big plans you may have in mind, Lal, but don't be reckless,' he told me, after he had secured a job for me with one of the lesser-known brokerage firms.

'There are plenty of rags-to-riches stories on Dalal Street that get talked about often. What does not get publicized as much are the riches-to-rags stories, which far outnumber the success stories. People get carried away, thinking it is easy to make money in the stock market, and learn the truth the hard way,' he said.

I knew Pradeep was speaking the truth, but I did not want to be weighed down by fear of failure so early in my career. If a steady job with a steady